

Frontera

Hinterlands to Homelands

Design Overview

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Overview

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1. Core Game Vision (*Victoria III*)

[My interpretation] Simulate a believable, **deep global economy** and **societal evolution**, prioritizing economic **management, industrialization, and trade influence** over map-painting warfare. The game aims to make the **player responsible for leading** their nation through the industrial era by **managing supply and demand chains** to maximize **GDP and influence**.

2. *Frontera* Expansion Vision

Abstraction of manifest destiny: *How and why* does a nation to **expand, populate, and govern** their frontier? Building upon *Victoria III*'s core vision, create new systems, and reuse/expand existing systems in order to provide the player interesting, historically *authentic* (as opposed to historically accurate), and meaningful choices surrounding expansion, settlement, and integration of new lands.

Long: How does a nation to **expand, populate, and govern** their frontier? What influences them to take on this colonial project? Building upon *Victoria III*'s core vision, *Frontera* is a mini-mod sized expansion that introduces new systems, and builds upon existing mechanics, to offer the player interesting, historically *authentic*, and meaningful choices surrounding expansion, settlement, and the integration of new lands. While the focusing on the North American west, these settlement mechanics can be used by any tag, assuming they meet the correct preconditions. This is related to how colonial laws, citizenship laws, and homesteading interact in a country's government.

Short: *Frontera* is a mini-mod introducing new mechanics focused on expanding, populating, and governing frontier territories.

3. Design Pillars

A: The Project of Frontier Colonization – A “Territorial Integration Life-cycle System”

Colonization is represented as a fragile state. Frontier colonization and the organization of territories is a viable representation of historic frontier colonization between “incorporated states” and “unincorporated states” – a procedural system pulls the incorporation process into discrete mechanics that the player can influence how and where incorporation can occur. Furthermore, this system must replicate itself where conditions become viable; that is, in other parts of the world beyond the USA, other nations could expand using these same mechanics. A frontier system can be used by a manifest Mexican colonization of the northern frontier, or the Russian eastward expansion, assuming conditions are met.

B: Conflict on the frontier – The colonists and locals have a say: We see situations where natives attempt to sway larger powers, or small bands of worse equipped rebels fight sustained guerrilla conflicts with more powerful armies. We see this with natives resisting the US and Mexico, but also star-flag revolts. What causes these sparse populations to revolt in such a way? Cultural fervor? Material conditions? How can I re-use and perhaps refine war mechanics to reflect this reality?

C: Alta California – “the content showcase” I can pull together as a territory of the USA / Mexico. I can fight frontier wars, or even strike out on my own. This *de facto* state provides a basis for western territorial game play.

4. Systems

A: The Project of Frontier Colonization:

1 - Affordance: Territorial Life-cycle System

Gameplay Loop:

1. Establish a territory
2. Gardening phase / attract, distribute, assimilate, and manage conflict among settler populations
3. The territory is integrated, collapses, or enters territorial perpetuity (change of government)
4. A new territory can be created in an adjacent region to new homelands

2 - Affordance: Instability levers – Attached with territorial lifecycle

Description: Further implementation of existing political movements toward territorial governance, with reverberations on overlord country

New Movements: Federalista and Centralista in Mexico + territories, inherited movements from overlord

Gameplay Loop:

1. Overlords top political movements provide options when establishing new territories (this place will be a beacon of liberty (liberal), a safe-haven from slavery (abolitionist), etc)
2. Established territory inherits political movements
3. Radicalism and pop-support for political movements create events, that may bounce back to overlord (when AI controlled territory, these events can be deferred to the overlord through opt C)
4. Resolving political movements for overlord may resolve issues for a territory, or incite revolt
5. Territory is annexed through territorial cycle (prev) or violent re-annexation via revolt
6. resume territorial lifecycle

B: Conflict on the Frontier: [Work in Progress]

Affordance: Guerrilla War Defensive Wargol

1. Upon phase escalation, I can choose to add this wargol and no others

(I can make this war into a guerrilla war, but it requires I sacrifice whatever ground I am holding, and become a political movement)

Affordance: Phase Escalation Wars

Gameplay Loop:

1. Aggressor invades defender: Interaction creates diplo play, skips directly to last quarter of diplo play no calling allies
 - 1.a. Done through diplomatic interaction
 - 1.b. Skips to last quarter of diplomatic play (no allies may be called)
 - 1.c. Attacker goal is **hold defenders capital state**
 - 1.d. Defender goal is **hold capital state**
 - 1.e. If aggressor fails, lines freeze, aggressor gains infamy, new diplomatic play
 - 1.f. If aggressor succeeds, sets up occupation government (insurgency can begin)

C: Alta California:

FOCUS: *The content showcase, the ground zero for narrative content*

Affordance: New movements and event chains surrounding the American West

Events:

1. Sutters Fort: The buying of Sutters fort offers an opportunity to create homelands/claims in CA
2. Existing US events are modified for synergy with new event chains
3. Gadsden Purchase (treaty of Mesilla): Split states in Arizona and New Mexico can be sold to the US to repair relations and intensify political rivalries on both sides (slavery in USA, Federalism in Mexico)
4. Federalist / Centralist political movements
5. New formable nations, Pacific States of America, Sonora, Cascadia, Deseret, Jefferson
5. Deseret event chain, Americans attempting to set up a LDS government from Utah

5. Roadmap

Phase 1

I. Territorial Lifecycle

- a) Define Laws/Government for territory
- b) State integration criteria (effect)
- c) State integration for overlord (scripted effect)
- d) State integration for territory (scripted effect)
- e) Territory creation (scripted event)
 - 1. Criteria for organized territory creation (journal entry)
 - 2. Define predetermined areas to be territories
- f) Territory creation (choice by colony)
 - 1. (first check) geographic regions / (then check) strategic regions
 - 1. OL has at least one full state in the region
 - 2. The state must be incorporated or a homeland
 - 2. (save scope of new OT region) activate journal button to make territory
 - 3. create territory out of all scoped states (include unincorporated parts of other terrs.)
 - 4. IF a territory has NO incorporated states, annex to overlord (allow tag switch to overlord)
- g) Territory creation (imposed on colony)
 - 1. Done through subject-overlord interaction
- h) Event for state to gain homeland
- i) Event for state to join the union

II. Sunset Route Event Chain

- a) Sunset Route Journal
- b) Sunset Route Event
- c) Treaty of Mesilla (Gadsden Purchase) Decision + Event Chain

Phase 2

I. Flavor/Events (goal of adding a new homeland for California/Utah)

- Fort Ross / Sutter's Fort event | December 1841

Mexican Centralists: Like a professional army, strong unitary government, controlled migration

Federalists: Like a people's army, decentralized elected government, uncontrolled migration

II. Fix USA journal entries

- Populating the American West
- Native resettlement
- Seminole wars [Just the event chain, I can revisit guerrilla wars later]

Test:

1. Events fire properly for ascendant states

Phase 3

- I. Flavor / events
- II. Removing Homelands / Reservation system
 - Homelands can be removed if a country 1) creates a reservation + 2) conquers / annexes a reservation; when the reservation is created, it moves all of X pops into a cluster of provinces within the reservation state named after culture
- III. Basic resistance pressure [this involves OT decisions to expand vs starting shit with locals]
- IV. Some kind of meaningful event / decision process for territories.
- V. Expansion doctrine engine [Countries gain an expansion doctrine]
- VI. Guerrilla escalation system
- VII. Replace any AI / Placeholder artwork with my own / community contribution

6. Specifications

GEOGRAPHIC TERRITORIAL REGIONS

New geographic regions are defined based on where historically viable territories were established. Usually this includes 2-4 states, and should be smaller than a strategic region. These can be used for establishing territories if available, otherwise, Organized Territories will be established composed of all held unincorporated non-homeland states sharing a strategic region with viable anchor state.

GOVERNMENT: ORGANIZED TERRITORY

Overview: Territories are demographic incubators. They grow population, shape demographics, and generate political pressures in their overlord country.

Description: "The state is legally a sub-division of a foreign power, possessing no sovereignty of its own. It has been granted limited authority to administer a patchwork of territorial holdings. By design, the territorial government is intended foster migration and population growth, with aspirations of eventual integration with their overlord."

- Each state requires milestone to be met in order to be quickly re-annexed by overlord
 - Must be a homeland for any overlord primary culture
- Each state requires a milestone to be met in order to become an overlord primary culture
 - Population > 85,000
 - 60% of pops have an acceptance of 100%
- **Organized Territories** receive a year-round migration boost to their capital state, and a partial boost to all other incorporated states in the **Organized Territory**
- These are agrarian areas where settlers may claim plots of land through homesteading policies, they receive the greatest bonuses to expansion with **Agrarianism and Homesteading**
- **Organized Territories** are created via a **Journal Entry Button** from regions of unincorporated non-homeland states under root control
- Playing as an **Organized Territory** allows for certain event chains to manipulate internal demographic growth and overlord events
- Creating a new **Organized Territory** affords a tag-switch to that new territory
- As an **Organized Territory**, giving up a state to overlord affords a tag-switch to the overlord.
- **Formation:** Click journal entry button to organize the territories [the timing for this decision is a meaningful choice]. States with frontier colonization and homesteading may transform colonial type governments into organized territories through a subject interaction
- **Subject Transformation:** Subjects to convert to territories should likely only include colonies, or should require a war or invasion of some kind with the owner
- **Policies:** Biased toward agrarian, low government presence, high personal autonomy
- **Culture:** Can change based on an overlord, similar to colonial government. Also has unique events to add acceptance for cultures with common heritages
- **Annexation:** Territories are annexed piecemeal based on requirements, that is, 60,000 citizens and a cultural homeland

- **Polarization:** Territories will exacerbate ongoing political movements. For example, the pro/anti slavery lobbies will gain events pertaining to how a territory is managed. For example, if there are slave states and free states, the admission of slaveholding or free territories can accelerate one side or the other. Violence or unrest in a state regarding a movement or institution can make its way back to the overlord.
- **Existing at Game Start:** Florida and Michigan start as Organized Territories of the USA. California and New Mexico begin as Organized Territories of Mexico.

COUNTRY: FLORIDA

Description: This is a starting pro-slavery territory of the USA. Later, it may be used as a vessel for a Seminole wars event chain or guerrilla war.

COUNTRY: MICHIGAN

Description: This is a starting free territory of the USA. *The Michigan Territory* affords the player a degree of immediate tutorialization for how organized territories function, as the state of Michigan begins the game ready for annexation, so the player will see the necessary annexation event a couple weeks into game-start.

COUNTRY: MEXICO

Political Movements: The Centralist vs Federalist split is pivotal in Mexico's history and instability throughout the 19th century. These movements should canalize Mexico's early political options, and increase the risk of radicals and revolts. While the Centralists will often be able to overthrow the government altogether, the Federalists will threaten to break away in secessionist movements. These movements exist in Mexico, as they are relevant in Mexico's territories such as California and New Mexico.

COUNTRY: NEW MEXICO

Description: This is a starting territory of Mexico. While it is not yet intended to be playable, New Mexico offers some opportunities for a flexible pioneer/mestizo game start, and for low-intensity guerrilla war showcasing once those mechanics are ready.

Characters:

Albino Perez: Governor, ambushed and killed by locals

Manuel Armijo: Governor to replace Perez

COUNTRY: ALTA CALIFORNIA

Description: This is a starting territory of Mexico, and a historically interesting de facto nation to play as. It is intended to be a challenging minor-country game, wherein the player aligns with a Great Power to break free of Mexico, or, enriches California and evolves into a *manifest Mexico*. This is also a launch point for another Great Power to integrate and control a frontier from the Pacific.

Flavor Text: “In 1821, the colony of Alta California was quick to declare its allegiance to a newly independent Mexico. Since then, Mexican authorities have been attempting to further integrate the territory, while tensions with colonists and local *Californio* leaders reach a boiling point. Surrounded by ambitious colonial powers, what will the future hold for the diverse peoples of Alta California?”

Characters:

Pio Pico: Last Alta-Californian Governor, ranchero of Mestizo and Afro-American heritage.

William Hartnell: British academic, Mexican citizen, assisted in translation of Californian law into English

Nicolas Gutierrez: Governor, Spaniard appointed by Mexican government to control California.

Carlos Carillo: Prominent aristocrat/ranchero, soldier

Juan Bautista Alvarado: Governor, attained power through coup against appointed Gov. Gutierrez.

John Sutter: Swiss-American pioneer who established the colony of New Helvatia in Mexican-controlled California. He was initially known as a popular destination point in California for migrants, such as the infamous Donner party. His fame increased after gold was discovered on his property in 1848, triggering the California Gold Rush, and his influence over the founding of Sacramento. His crimes against California native populations are well documented.

Isaac Graham: Pioneer colonist, hotheaded Yankee

7. Journals | Decisions | Event Chains

JOURNAL: ESTABLISH ORGANIZED TERRITORY

Trigger: Country has *Homesteading* and *Frontier Colonization*

Remove JE: Country no longer has *Homesteading* or *Frontier Colonization*

Buttons: Most games should end with Sutters Fort, and California becoming a yankee homeland

EVENT CHAIN: SALE OF FORT ROSS

Trigger: Date requirement, California is a split state

Endstate: A new primary culture, homeland, or claim is added to California, stops being a split state

Historical: Most games should end with Sutters Fort, and California becoming a yankee homeland

<https://www.figma.com/design/bByxOUIXbzDSYG0XarUL3b/Frontera?node-id=0-1&p=f&m=draw>

DECISION: TREATY OF MESILLA

Trigger: (*NOT – Global variable Sunset route has been built*). AZ or NM is split state. No nations in AZ or NMX are decentralized. Own all of Texas, own all of California, have a state in Arizona, have a state in New Mexico.

Endstate: Mexico is destabilized between Centralist and Federalist. USA is destabilized in slavery debate. Initiator pays 50 000 to recipient (AI will do if they have twice the money)

Historical: Yes

Effect:

Trigger event “Treaty of Mesilla” for all other countries with states in NMX or AZ

EVENT: TREATY OF MESILLA

Trigger: Triggered by decision

Effect Opt A: (historical, army is weak) Make the sale (all states in NM or AZ go to INITIATOR), increase pop radicalism / joining radical groups – sign the treaty, get money

Effect Opt B: (my army is strong) Diplomatic incident, opponent gets infamy, claims the land

JOURNAL: THE SUNSET ROUTE

Trigger:

(NOT – Global variable Sunset route has been built), In north America

BUTTON PRESS ALLOWED:

All states in CAL, AZ, NM, TX, each have combined railroad level of 2

Success: Variable: Sunset Route has been built

Effect:

Trigger event: “The Sunset Route”

EVENT CHAIN: THE SUNSET ROUTE

Trigger: Journal button press (see last)

Effect:

IF = Any state in CAL, AZ, NM, TX

OWNER is same country OR has good relations with owner of ANY state in CAL, AZ, NM, TX

1.(**bad**) If a country has bad relations, save that, spit back event (the non-cooperation of mexican transport hubs is impeding the connection of our infrastructure) [button cooldown for 2 years]

2.(**good**) The connections of rail lines between Cal, Az, Nm, and Tx, have opened for public service, they are now known as the sunset route (add decaying migration attraction to each state for 15-20 years), any owner of the states add +5% union attraction. Set global variable, Sunset Route built
Delete the sante fe trail [complete this JE]

if the US owns NMX and AZ, and has railroad in each. Trigger event: "The Sunset Route" – This will quietly remove the Sante Fe trail, and will provide a fading immigration boosts to any state in California or the Northwest that is owned by the THIS, is a subject of THIS, or has friendly relations with the THIS. The Sunset Route Event nullifies the Gadsden Purchase (Treaty of Mesilla).

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